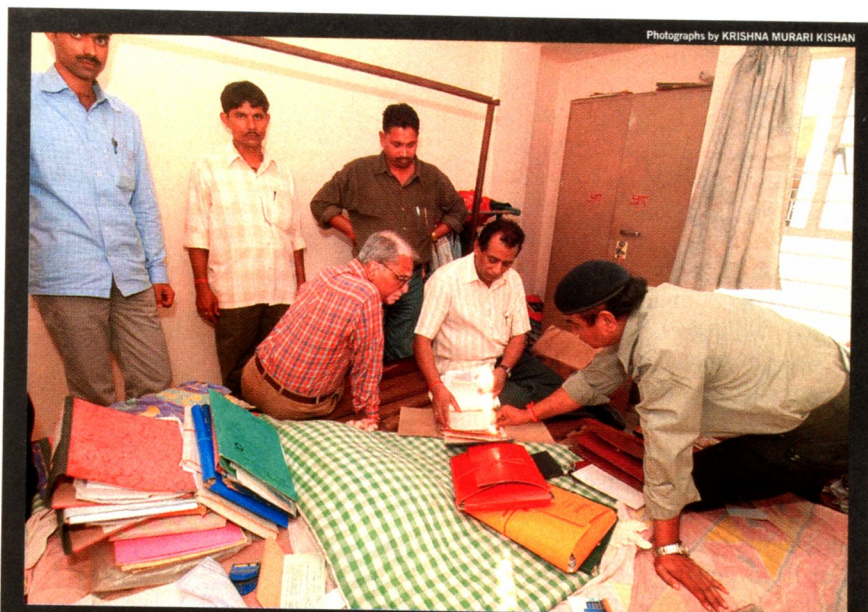


■ By Amitabh Srivastava

There was a time when corruption was virtually a risk free business in Bihar. And to those who practised it with impunity, it always paid rich dividends. Like other states, Bihar too has a Vigilance Bureau but till two years back it used to be mostly in the sleep mode. Between 1995-2005, the bureau trapped a mere 47 officials taking bribes. Worse, it could procure no sanction to prosecute them but the tables have now turned. In 22 months since January 2006, the bureau has laid 153 traps and caught more than 178 public servants including IAS and IPS officers, engineers, and senior officials of the forest department. Final charge sheets against more than 140 government officials arrested in the last two years have already been filed.

That's not all. The state Government has now set up a special court at Patna to ensure speedy trial of cases involving government officials caught red-handed accepting bribes. Vigilance Commissioner V.K. Verma says: "Cases registered against officials caught in traps would be shifted to the special court. We are determined to secure conviction against them, as this will be the only effective deterrent against corruption."

The notification to set up a special court has been issued in concurrence with the Patna High Court. Additional District and Sessions Judge, Patna, Qayum Khan will head the court which has been constituted after vigorous efforts by the Vigilance Bureau. The court is expected to start functioning by next month and will begin trial of graft cases lodged between 2006 and 2007. Additional Director General of Police, Vigilance, Neelmani says the special court will help speed up cases as the other two vigilance courts have a large backlog. Cutting down backlog is important because delays in trials are the excuse the bribery-accused give while seeking bail. Neelmani, a 1975 batch IPS officer, explained: "The court



Photographs by KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN

VIGILANT AT LAST

The state Vigilance Bureau has finally become pro-active, trapping, raiding and suspending dishonest officials and filing chargesheets in many cases



will take up those cases initially where we have procured sanctions to prosecute officials caught red handed accepting bribes between 2006-07. There would be nearly 200 such cases."

The Vigilance Bureau has been given operational freedom to an extent that the state government has provided it with funds to be used as trap money to bribe officials with. Earlier, the complainant had to pay the bribe from his own pocket which was a big deterrent. The bribe money would remain locked till the court would pronounce its verdict but now the bureau will pay back

RAIDING THE LAIR: A search (top); Engineer Vinay Kumar Singh (above)

an equal amount to the complainant while the bribe money will stay as court exhibit. The Bihar Government has also constituted a separate wing called Special Vigilance Unit, headed by Inspector General of Police, A.K. Upadhyay, to identify and target the corrupt from amongst senior government officials. Neelmani says: "Twelve retired CBI officials have been hired to strengthen the unit." A Home Department official added that more CBI officials will beef up the vigilance set-up.

The question on everyone's minds is whether the raids and the special court are generating hype or are things actually getting better in the state? Deputy Chief Minister Sushil Kumar Modi says, "We have given complete



"The special court will help us cut down the backlog of cases against corrupt officials."

NEELMANI, ADG, VIGILANCE, BIHAR